CDL Combination Vehicles Test Questions and Answers

46 practice questions with answers and explanations, grouped by topic

Written from the Commercial Driver's License Manual (Version 07/20/2026 (form DMV 60A), AAMVA, Virginia DMV edition). Each answer names the manual section it comes from.

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How to use this PDF: answer the questions in Part 1 first, then check yourself with the answer key in Part 2.

Passing score on each CDL knowledge test: at least 80% correct (49 CFR 383.135).

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Part 1: Questions

Driving combinations safely (11 questions)

1. **While backing a trailer, you see it start to drift off the proper path. How should you correct it?**
   - **A.** Turn the top of the steering wheel away from the drift
   - **B.** Hold the wheel straight and let the trailer settle
   - **C.** Turn the top of the steering wheel in the direction of the drift
   - **D.** Speed up slightly so the trailer straightens out

2. **Compared with a tractor-semitrailer loaded to maximum gross weight, how does a bobtail tractor (a tractor with no semitrailer) stop?**
   - **A.** It takes longer to stop
   - **B.** It stops in about half the distance
   - **C.** It stops in the same distance
   - **D.** It stops faster but pulls to one side

3. **How does the stopping distance of a large combination vehicle compare when it is empty versus fully loaded?**
   - **A.** It is shorter when empty
   - **B.** It is the same whether empty or loaded
   - **C.** It is shorter when empty, except on wet roads
   - **D.** It is longer when empty

4. **When pulling trailers at more than 40 mph, how much following distance does the manual call for?**
   - **A.** At least 1 second for each 10 feet of vehicle length, plus 1 more second
   - **B.** At least 1 second for each 20 feet of vehicle length, plus 1 more second
   - **C.** At least 2 seconds for each 10 feet of vehicle length, with no extra time
   - **D.** At least 1 second for each 10 feet of vehicle length, with no extra time

5. **What is more likely if the load sits to one side so that it makes the trailer lean?**
   - **A.** The trailer brakes failing
   - **B.** The air-lines coming apart
   - **C.** The fifth wheel unlocking
   - **D.** The rig rolling over

6. **In a rig with more than one trailer, which wheels off-track the most in a turn?**
   - **A.** The rear wheels of the tractor
   - **B.** The rear wheels of the first trailer
   - **C.** The front wheels of the tractor
   - **D.** The rear wheels of the last trailer

7. **On the rearward amplification scale, what does a value of 2.0 mean?**
   - **A.** The rear trailer weighs twice as much as the tractor
   - **B.** The rear trailer is twice as likely to turn over as the tractor
   - **C.** The rear trailer needs twice the stopping distance of the tractor
   - **D.** The rear trailer off-tracks twice as far as the tractor

8. **According to the manual, about what share of truck driver deaths in crashes result from truck rollovers?**
   - **A.** Fewer than one in ten
   - **B.** About one in five
   - **C.** More than half
   - **D.** About one in three

9. **If your rig gets stuck on railroad tracks, what should you do first?**
   - **A.** Stay in the cab and keep trying to rock the rig free
   - **B.** Lower the landing gear to lift the trailer off the rails
   - **C.** Get out of the vehicle and away from the tracks
   - **D.** Stay in the cab and call 911 for help

10. **Once you see in your mirrors that the trailer has started to skid, what should you do with the brakes?**
    - **A.** Apply them harder to stop the rig quickly
    - **B.** Release them so the wheels get traction back
    - **C.** Pump them rapidly until the skid stops
    - **D.** Hold steady pressure on them until the rig stops

11. **If you cannot complete a turn without entering another traffic lane, when should you turn wide?**
    - **A.** Before starting the turn, by swinging wide to the left
    - **B.** As you complete the turn
    - **C.** At the very start, before the front wheels reach the corner
    - **D.** At no point; keep the whole rig in your own lane

Combination air brakes (11 questions)

12. On newer vehicles, what does the trailer air supply control look like?

- **A.** A blue round knob
- **B.** A yellow diamond-shaped knob
- **C.** A red eight-sided knob
- **D.** A black lever on the steering column

13. If you cross the air-lines when coupling, where does the supply air go?

- **A.** To the service line instead of charging the trailer air tanks
- **B.** Back into the tractor's main air tanks instead
- **C.** Out through the drain valves on the trailer tanks
- **D.** Straight to the trailer spring brakes, releasing them

14. How often should you drain each trailer air tank?

- **A.** Once a week
- **B.** Every day
- **C.** Once a month
- **D.** Only when the brakes start to feel weak

15. What color is often used to code emergency air-lines so they are not mixed up with service lines?

- **A.** Red
- **B.** Blue
- **C.** Yellow
- **D.** Green

16. When you connect glad hands, how should the couplers be held as you press the two seals together?

- **A.** Parallel to each other
- **B.** At a 45 degree angle to each other
- **C.** End to end in a straight line
- **D.** At a 90 degree angle to each other

17. Why should you never use the trailer hand valve to park?

- **A.** All the air might leak out and unlock the brakes
- **B.** It applies the tractor brakes much too hard
- **C.** It closes the tractor protection valve right away
- **D.** It drains the air from the tractor tanks

18. Which units are not required to have spring brakes?

- **A.** Trailers built after March 1, 1998
- **B.** Converter dollies and trailers built before 1975
- **C.** Any trailer used to tow another trailer
- **D.** Trucks and truck tractors built before 1975

19. When might you first notice a major leak in the service line?

- **A.** When you first start the engine
- **B.** When you push in the trailer air supply control
- **C.** During a sharp turn
- **D.** When you try to put the brakes on

20. What do shut-off valves (cut-out cocks) in the trailer air-lines allow you to do?

- **A.** Drain water and oil from the trailer air tanks
- **B.** Release the trailer spring brakes by hand
- **C.** Close off the air-lines when no other trailer is towed
- **D.** Keep air in the tractor if the trailer breaks away

21. When the tractor protection valve closes, what happens to the trailer?

- **A.** The trailer brakes are fully released
- **B.** The trailer service line gets extra air pressure
- **C.** The trailer air tanks are refilled from the tractor
- **D.** The trailer emergency brakes come on

22. The tractor protection valve closes automatically when air pressure falls into what range?

- **A.** 60 to 80 psi
- **B.** 20 to 45 psi
- **C.** 100 to 125 psi
- **D.** 5 to 10 psi

Trailer antilock brakes (4 questions)

23. What does ABS do for you during hard braking?

- **A.** It always shortens your stopping distance on any road
- **B.** It helps you keep control but may not shorten stopping distance
- **C.** It adds extra braking power to your normal brakes
- **D.** It lets you safely follow other vehicles more closely

24. If the ABS on your combination vehicle malfunctions, what should you do?

- **A.** Stop and do not move the vehicle until it is repaired
- **B.** Drive only in the right lane at reduced speed until it is repaired
- **C.** Brake only with the trailer hand valve until it is repaired
- **D.** Drive normally and get the system serviced soon

25. Trailers and converter dollies built on or after what date are required to have ABS?

- **A.** January 1, 1975
- **B.** March 1, 1988
- **C.** March 1, 1998
- **D.** January 1, 2008

26. Only your trailer has ABS, and you start a tractor jackknife. What should you do?

- **A.** Let up on the brakes, if safe, until you regain control
- **B.** Brake harder so the trailer ABS can take over
- **C.** Apply the trailer hand valve to straighten the rig
- **D.** Pull out the trailer air supply control right away

Coupling and uncoupling (15 questions)

27. Which gear should you use to back the tractor under the trailer?

- **A.** The highest reverse gear
- **B.** Neutral, letting the tractor roll back
- **C.** Any reverse gear, as long as the engine is at idle
- **D.** The lowest reverse gear

28. After backing under the trailer, how do you check that the trailer is locked onto the tractor?

- **A.** Release the trailer brakes and back up firmly against it
- **B.** Pull gently forward while the trailer brakes are still locked
- **C.** Drive a short loop around the lot with the landing gear down
- **D.** Rock the trailer by hand from the rear bumper

29. When coupling a drawbar, what does the manual say if the safety cover bar will not lodge properly into its seating?

- **A.** Travel is strictly forbidden
- **B.** You may drive slowly to a repair shop
- **C.** Tighten the lock screws further and drive on
- **D.** Use the safety chains in its place

30. What is the first step when uncoupling a drawbar?

- **A.** Remove the rubber dust proof bellows cover
- **B.** Make sure the trailer brake is on
- **C.** Rotate the safety cover bar outwards
- **D.** Lift the trailer drawbeam

31. When uncoupling, why do you back up gently after shutting off the trailer air supply?

- **A.** To ease pressure on the fifth wheel locking jaws
- **B.** To set the trailer spring brakes before unhooking
- **C.** To line the tractor up straight with the trailer
- **D.** To lower the landing gear onto the ground

32. Before coupling, how should the fifth wheel be set?

- **A.** Level, with the jaws closed
- **B.** Tilted down toward the rear of the tractor, with the jaws open
- **C.** Tilted up toward the cab, with the jaws open
- **D.** Tilted down toward the rear of the tractor, with the jaws closed

33. What problem can happen if the fifth wheel plate is not kept lubricated?

- **A.** Steering problems from tractor-trailer friction
- **B.** Air leaks at the glad hands when the rig turns
- **C.** The landing gear will not raise all the way
- **D.** The trailer lights will flicker or fail

34. When you pull the tractor partly clear during uncoupling, why should you stop with the tractor frame still under the trailer?

- **A.** So the air-lines can still be disconnected safely
- **B.** So the trailer won't fall if the landing gear gives way
- **C.** So the fifth wheel can be greased before you leave
- **D.** So the trailer brakes can be tested one last time

35. When uncoupling a gooseneck hitch, what does the coupler do after you rotate the handle and raise the trailer off the ball?

- **A.** It returns to the load position automatically
- **B.** It must be reset by hand with a wrench
- **C.** It locks back onto the ball
- **D.** It releases the trailer brakes

36. What does the manual say about safety chains when hooking up a gooseneck trailer?

- **A.** They are needed only on loaded trailers
- **B.** They are optional once the clamp is latched
- **C.** All trailers are required by law to have them
- **D.** They are used only with pintle hooks

37. When uncoupling a loaded trailer, what should you do after the landing gear makes firm contact with the ground?

- **A.** Stop cranking right away
- **B.** Keep cranking until the trailer lifts off the fifth wheel
- **C.** Turn the crank in low gear a few extra turns
- **D.** Switch to high gear and crank until the gear is fully extended

38. Why should you never back under a trailer at an angle?

- **A.** The air-lines could get crossed or pulled loose
- **B.** The trailer brakes could release and let it roll
- **C.** You might push the trailer sideways and break the landing gear
- **D.** The kingpin could bend against the edge of the fifth wheel

39. When uncoupling a pintle hook, what must you check before extending the jack?

- **A.** That the safety chains are still attached to the tow vehicle
- **B.** That all the trailer lights and brake lights work
- **C.** That the ground under the jack pad can hold the tongue load
- **D.** That the drawbar eye has been freshly greased

40. When a pintle hook latch is pushed closed and correctly locked, what does the lock handle do?

- **A.** It drops down below the bottom of the latch
- **B.** It pops out of the hook body and hangs free
- **C.** It stays loose so it can be turned by hand
- **D.** It rotates and moves up flush with the latch top

41. When you secure the vehicle before inspecting the coupling, why should you take the key with you?

- **A.** So nobody else moves the truck while you are under it
- **B.** So the trailer brakes stay applied while you check
- **C.** So the air pressure does not drop while you work
- **D.** So the electrical cord cannot be unplugged by mistake

Inspecting a combination vehicle (5 questions)

42. When inspecting the air-lines to the trailer, what should you check about how they are secured?

- **A.** They are pulled tight so they cannot move
- **B.** They are taped to the electrical cord
- **C.** They hang loose enough to rest on the frame
- **D.** They are secured with enough slack for turns

43. Why do you check that a sliding fifth wheel is not set too far forward?

- **A.** The trailer would sit too low for the landing gear to clear the ground
- **B.** The fifth wheel grease would wear off the plate much faster
- **C.** The frame could hit the landing gear, or the cab the trailer, in turns
- **D.** The air-lines would be too short to reach the trailer glad hands

44. During a walk-around inspection, where should the fifth wheel locking jaws be?

- **A.** Around the head of the kingpin, not the shank
- **B.** Around the base of the kingpin, not the shank
- **C.** Around the shank of the kingpin, not the head
- **D.** Around both the head and the base of the kingpin

45. On a sliding fifth wheel, what should you check about the locking pins?

- **A.** They are all present and locked in place
- **B.** At least half of them are engaged
- **C.** They are removed before driving
- **D.** They are pulled out so the slide moves freely

46. What can happen if the tractor protection valve does not work right?

- **A.** The trailer spring brakes would not apply when parked
- **B.** The trailer ABS warning lamp would stay on
- **C.** The trailer service brakes would apply too slowly
- **D.** A hose or trailer brake leak could drain all the tractor's air

Part 2: Answer key

Each answer has a short explanation in our own words and the CDL manual section it comes from. Reread that section for every question you missed.

Driving combinations safely

1. **C. Turn the top of the steering wheel in the direction of the drift**
   Fix the drift right away by turning the top of the wheel toward the side the trailer is drifting to; backing slowly gives you time to make these corrections.
   Manual section 6.1.7 Backing with a Trailer

2. **A. It takes longer to stop**
   Tests show a tractor running without a semitrailer is hard to stop smoothly and needs more distance than a fully loaded tractor-semitrailer.
   Manual section 6.1.3 Brake Early

3. **D. It is longer when empty**
   A lightly loaded rig has poor traction because of its stiff springs and strong brakes, so it needs more distance to stop than a full one.
   Manual section 6.1.3 Brake Early

4. **A. At least 1 second for each 10 feet of vehicle length, plus 1 more second**
   The base rule is one second per 10 feet of rig length, and above 40 mph you add one more second on top of that.
   Manual section 6.1.2 Steer Gently

5. **D. The rig rolling over**
   An off-center load shifts weight to one side of the trailer and raises the chance of tipping over, so cargo should be centered and spread out.
   Manual section 6.1.1 Rollover Risks

6. **D. The rear wheels of the last trailer**
   Off-tracking grows toward the back of the rig: the tractor's rear wheels off-track some, a trailer's more, and the last trailer's rear wheels the most.
   Manual section 6.1.6 Turn Wide

7. **B. The rear trailer is twice as likely to turn over as the tractor**
   Rearward amplification compares how easily the rear trailer rolls with the tractor, so a value of 2.0 means the rear trailer is two times as likely to roll.
   Manual section 6.1.2 Steer Gently

8. **C. More than half**
   Rollovers account for the majority of truck driver crash deaths, which is why keeping the rig upright matters so much.
   Manual section 6.1.1 Rollover Risks

9. **C. Get out of the vehicle and away from the tracks**
   Leave the rig and move clear of the rails before anything else; then look for the emergency information posted at the crossing and call for help.
   Manual section 6.1.4 Railroad-highway Crossings

10. **B. Release them so the wheels get traction back**
    Letting off the brakes allows the trailer wheels to roll and grip the road again, and then the trailer starts to follow the tractor and straighten out.
    Manual section 6.1.5 Prevent Trailer Skids

11. **B. As you complete the turn**
    Going wide at the end of the turn keeps the rear of the rig near the curb so other drivers cannot pass on the right, which swinging left first would allow.
    Manual section 6.1.6 Turn Wide

Combination air brakes

12. **C. A red eight-sided knob**
    Newer rigs use a red knob with eight sides in the cab to work the tractor protection valve.
    Manual section 6.2.3 Trailer Air Supply Control

13. **A. To the service line instead of charging the trailer air tanks**
    With the lines crossed, the air meant to fill the trailer tanks ends up in the service line, so no air is available to release the trailer spring brakes.
    Manual section 6.2.5 Hose Couplers (Glad Hands)

14. **B. Every day**
    Daily draining keeps water and oil from building up and spoiling brake performance; even tanks with automatic drains should be opened to make sure.
    Manual section 6.2.6 Trailer Air Tanks

15. **A. Red**
    Red hoses, couplers or other parts mark the emergency line, while blue marks the service line.
    Manual section 6.2.4 Trailer Air-lines

16. **D. At a 90 degree angle to each other**
    The seals go together with the couplers at right angles, and then a turn of the glad hand on the hose joins and locks them.
    Manual section 6.2.5 Hose Couplers (Glad Hands)

17. **A. All the air might leak out and unlock the brakes**
    The hand valve holds the trailer with air, and on a trailer without spring brakes that air can leak away and let the brakes go, so use the parking brakes instead.
    Manual section 6.2.1 Trailer Hand Valve

18. **B. Converter dollies and trailers built before 1975**
    Converter dollies and trailers from before 1975 may lack spring brakes and rely on emergency brakes that run on air stored in the trailer tank.
    Manual section 6.2.8 Trailer Service, Parking and Emergency Brakes

19. **D. When you try to put the brakes on**
    A service line leak can stay hidden until you brake, when the escaping air quickly drops tank pressure and may set off the trailer emergency brakes.
    Manual section 6.2.8 Trailer Service, Parking and Emergency Brakes

20. **C. Close off the air-lines when no other trailer is towed**
    These valves let you seal off the service and supply lines when no other trailer is hooked up behind.
    Manual section 6.2.7 Shut-off Valves

21. **D. The trailer emergency brakes come on**
    A closed valve stops air leaving the tractor and vents the trailer's emergency line, so the trailer emergency brakes apply, possibly with loss of control.
    Manual section 6.2.2 Tractor Protection Valve

22. **B. 20 to 45 psi**
    Once pressure gets low, roughly 20 to 45 psi, the valve shuts on its own so the tractor keeps its air.
    Manual section 6.2.2 Tractor Protection Valve

Trailer antilock brakes

23. **B. It helps you keep control but may not shorten stopping distance**
ABS works to prevent wheel lockup so you stay in control; it does not promise a shorter stop and adds no extra braking power.
Manual section 6.3.2 Braking with ABS

24. **D. Drive normally and get the system serviced soon**
A failed ABS still leaves your regular brakes working, so you can keep driving as usual but should have the system fixed soon.
Manual section 6.3.2 Braking with ABS

25. **C. March 1, 1998**
The ABS requirement covers trailers and converter dollies built from March 1, 1998 onward, though many older units were fitted with ABS voluntarily.
Manual section 6.3.1 Trailers Required to Have ABS

26. **A. Let up on the brakes, if safe, until you regain control**
Trailer ABS makes the trailer less likely to swing out but does not prevent a tractor jackknife, so ease off the brakes when it is safe until the tractor is back under control.
Manual section 6.3.2 Braking with ABS

Coupling and uncoupling

27. **D. The lowest reverse gear**
Backing slowly in the lowest reverse gear keeps you from striking the kingpin too hard, and you stop once it is locked into the fifth wheel.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

28. **B. Pull gently forward while the trailer brakes are still locked**
With the landing gear raised slightly off the ground, a gentle tug forward against the locked trailer brakes shows whether the trailer has latched onto the tractor.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

29. **A. Travel is strictly forbidden**
If the safety cover bar does not sit correctly in its seat, the vehicle must not be driven at all.
Manual section 6.4.5 Coupling a Drawbar

30. **B. Make sure the trailer brake is on**
Drawbar uncoupling starts with confirming the trailer brake is applied; only after that do you remove the cover and loosen the screws.
Manual section 6.4.6 Uncoupling a Drawbar

31. **A. To ease pressure on the fifth wheel locking jaws**
Backing gently takes the strain off the fifth wheel jaws, which makes the release lever easier to work; the parking brakes then hold the rig in that position.
Manual section 6.4.2 Uncoupling Tractor-Semitrailers

32. **B. Tilted down toward the rear of the tractor, with the jaws open**
For coupling, the fifth wheel should slope down toward the back of the tractor with its jaws open and the safety unlocking handle in the automatic lock position.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

33. **A. Steering problems from tractor-trailer friction**
Without enough grease, the tractor and trailer rub against each other at the fifth wheel, and that friction can make the rig hard to steer.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

34. **B. So the trailer won't fall if the landing gear gives way**
The frame acts as a backup support in case the landing gear gives way, and you then secure the tractor and inspect the trailer supports.
Manual section 6.4.2 Uncoupling Tractor-Semitrailers

35. **A. It returns to the load position automatically**
Once the trailer is lifted off the ball, the coupler resets itself to the load position, and you then put the safety pin and clip back in.
Manual section 6.4.8 Uncoupling a Gooseneck Hitch

36. **C. All trailers are required by law to have them**
Attaching safety chains is a required step because the law calls for them on every trailer.
Manual section 6.4.7 Coupling a Gooseneck Hitch

37. **C. Turn the crank in low gear a few extra turns**
A few extra low-gear turns take some weight off the tractor without lifting the trailer off the fifth wheel, which makes unlatching and the next coupling easier.
Manual section 6.4.2 Uncoupling Tractor-Semitrailers

38. **C. You might push the trailer sideways and break the landing gear**
Backing in crooked can shove the trailer to the side and damage its landing gear, so put the tractor directly in front of the trailer first.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

39. **C. That the ground under the jack pad can hold the tongue load**
The jack is about to carry the weight of the trailer tongue, so the surface under its pad has to be firm enough to hold that load.
Manual section 6.4.4 Uncoupling a Pintle Hook

40. **D. It rotates and moves up flush with the latch top**
A good lock shows itself by the handle turning and rising to sit even with the top of the latch; then the tethered lock pin goes in, if the hook has one.
Manual section 6.4.3 Coupling a Pintle Hook

41. **A. So nobody else moves the truck while you are under it**
You will be working underneath the rig, so keeping the key on you prevents someone from driving it while you are in harm's way.
Manual section 6.4.1 Coupling Tractor-Semitrailers

Inspecting a combination vehicle

42. **D. They are secured with enough slack for turns**
The lines should be connected to the glad hands without leaks and fastened so they still have enough give for the rig to turn.
Manual section 6.5.1 Additional Things to Check during a Walk-around Inspection

43. **C. The frame could hit the landing gear, or the cab the trailer, in turns**
With the fifth wheel too far forward, the tractor frame can strike the landing gear and the cab can strike the trailer when the rig turns.
Manual section 6.5.1 Additional Things to Check during a Walk-around Inspection

44. **C. Around the shank of the kingpin, not the head**
The locking jaws belong around the kingpin's shank; jaws closed on the head instead mean the coupling is not right.
Manual section 6.5.1 Additional Things to Check during a Walk-around Inspection

45. **A. They are all present and locked in place**

Every locking pin on the slide has to be there and locked; a missing or unlocked pin is a problem to fix before driving.

Manual section 6.5.1 Additional Things to Check during a Walk-around Inspection

46. **D. A hose or trailer brake leak could drain all the tractor's air**

The valve is meant to save the tractor's air when the trailer side leaks; if it fails, all that air can be lost, the emergency brakes come on, and control may be lost.

Manual section 6.5.2 Combination Vehicle Brake Check

Keep practicing online

This list with a hide-answers switch: https://cdl-testprep.com/cdl-practice-test/combination-vehicles/questions-and-answers/
Every CDL practice test: https://cdl-testprep.com/cdl-practice-test/